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Title:

The Bright Side of Death

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The Bright Side of Death
by Carlos Zayas

Guard: Felix, here is your cell and cellmate, Tristan. Both of you are set to be executed on the morrow. Spend your final hours thinking on your sins and may the gods have mercy on your souls.

Felix: Good eventide to you! (cheerfully)

Tristan: What are you so excited about? (slightly irritated)

Felix: Tomorrow I will be returning to my family whom I have lost. Isn't that wonderful?

Tristan: Tomorrow you will die, descend into Tartarus, and suffer for all eternity. Isn't that wonderful?

Felix: Nonono, why would I end up in Tartarus? I have done nothing wrong!

Tristan: In that case, you must be in the wrong place because, last time I checked, murder is wrong.

Felix: That's rich coming from a murderer. (contently)

Tristan: Isn't it? (sarcastically) (a beat) So did you murder anyone or not?

Felix: Well, I didn't "murder" anyone…

Tristan: Then what are you here for? Treason? Rape? High-stakes confidence tricks?

Felix: Confidence tricks?

Tristan: (sigh) Have you ever heard of a con?

Felix: As in a negative side effect or a sort of monetary scam?

Tristan: Which would you think could result in death?

Felix: I feel like most people, excluding myself, would consider death a negative side effect.

Tristan: (fuming silence)

Felix: I'm going to assume the latter.

Tristan: I can’t believe that someone such as yourself managed to muddle through the thought process of such an elaborate crime…

Felix: So you believe that I’m not capable of such a heinous crime?

Tristan: (a beat) Yes. (sternly)

Felix: Fantastic! We have established my innocence!

Tristan: (sputtering) ...Sure. (a beat) So now will you tell me WHY you are here?

Felix: I asked to be. (matter-of-factly)

Tristan: (a beat) You asked to be executed?

Felix: Yes!

Tristan: At this point, that sounds completely reasonable.

Felix: Now do you understand why I am so elated?

Tristan: If only I could share your enthusiasm... (a beat) Then why didn’t you just commit suicide? Wouldn’t that be faster than waiting for a public execution?

Felix: Suicide is a coward’s way out. (devotedly)

Tristan: And asking to be killed isn’t?

Felix: Eh, semantics.

Tristan: I beg to differ.

Felix: No need to beg, you can be wrong if you want to be.

Tristan: I didn’t murder my boss, spend months on the run from the law, get arrested by my own friends, and get put to death so that I could argue semantics with a maniac!!! (Growing in anger as the sentence goes on)

Felix: How rude! You call me a maniac AND you are unprepared to quarrel over semantics? Have you never been in an educated discussion before?

Tristan: (still fuming) Alright, I'm fed up with this stupidity! Guard! GUARD! YES, YOU! What is HE dying for?! (pointing at Felix)

Felix: I've shared this with you already! I asked to be here! (hurriedly and worriedly)

Guard: In a manner of speaking I suppose. He turned himself in… after confessing to the murder of his wife and child.

Felix: I didn't "murder" them…

Tristan: (interrupting) You are a filthy liar!

Felix: As if lying is of high import on your moral scale.

Tristan: SHUT UP! We are the same, don't you see?

Felix: Don't put me on your level, killer! (shrill)

Tristan: You are just as much a killer as I am! Maybe even more so considering you murdered your own family!

Felix: I did not "murder" them!

Tristan: Then give me a GOOD reason for being here! One that isn't, "I asked to be here bluhbluhbluh."

Felix: They were in pain. I had to stop it. (matter-of-factly)

Tristan: (a beat) Oh goodness, you're a psycho. (frightened)

Felix: You already called me a maniac, do you have to persist in these accusations?

Tristan: No, I was insulting you with calling you maniac. You are legitimately a psychopath.

Felix: Congratulations! You're the first person I've talked to in months that has used legitimately in a correct setting!

Tristan: So you're admitting to being a psychopath?

Felix: No, I'm simply stating that you used the word correctly given your belief that I am, in fact, clinically insane.

Tristan: (nervously laughing) I'm glad I could make your day, Felix. (in a hushed voice) Hey, Guard, can I get moved to

another cell. With this guy around, one of us may not make it to our execution party.

Guard: Against protocol, my apologies.

Tristan: Darn you, you responsible employee! (angrily sarcastic) (a beat) So, Felix…

Felix: Yes, Tristan?

Tristan: What exactly qualifies as "in pain"? Am I in pain?

Felix: Are you? I could fix that!(excitedly)

Tristan: NOPE, I'M GOOD. Just… curious about your family… hehe…

Felix: My wife was the most wonderful woman I had ever met: gorgeous, intelligent, gentle, loving… Oh how I miss her! And my daughter, she was duplicate of her mother! I could tell, even as a newborn, that she was going to be just like her mother within a few years. She had greatness to look forward to!

Tristan: Then why is she… dead?

Felix: Childbirth is a painfully long process, especially when there are no trained professionals around to help.

Tristan: You killed them in the middle of the birth of your first child?

Felix: Killed is such a strong word… I helped them!

Tristan: By ending their lives?

Felix: Must we go over this again?

Tristan: Right right, sorry sorry.

Felix: Now, as I have narrated my tale to you, I feel it only fair for you to tell me why you are here! Previously, you mentioned (clears throat) quote: "I didn't murder my boss, spend months on the run from the law, get arrested by my own friends, and get put to death so that I could argue semantics with a maniac!!!" End quote. By the way, the section calling me a maniac still hurts.

Tristan: Right, sorry about that. (more nervous laughter) It would probably be more appropriate to call him my ex-boss…

Felix: (interrupting) Because you murdered him!

Tristan: Huh, I guess that you're right in that line of thinking but before that, he fired me. I was working my way to the top in the mercenary business when our contractor cut us out of a job. We did our work fully and justly…

Felix: (interrupting) As justly as a mercenary can! (laughing)

Tristan: Hehe… yeah… Anyways, we were cut out of our pay so we confronted him. He told us that if we didn't hush up about it, he would let our whole company go! At that point, the fuel of fury and the imminent injustice…

Felix: (interrupting) Nice alliteration!

Tristan: (a beat) I would really appreciate it if you stopped interrupting me. (silent anger)

Felix: Oh right, my apologies!

Tristan: So at that point, I just couldn't control myself any longer and in a fit of blind emotion, I slit his throat in front of all my men. That was my downfall. Suddenly, all of my men turned against me calling me "murderer" and "barbarian". My closest friends were now against me. It took me about a minute to realize what I had done.

Felix: You killed a man?

Tristan: No, I've killed men in the past. Mercenary, remember?

Felix: Ahh… continue!

Tristan: I've killed men before, but never out of rage. It was always for money, justice, or necessity but not this time. Blind rage drove me to kill a man I had known for years without legitimate purpose. It scared me to know what the powers of emotion can do to a person. They can break us. So I ran and ran for months and months, figuratively of course. All the while, it was my old mercenary buddies that were hunting me, not the imperial guard or anything like that. My closest friends, the men I had work with for years, were the ones who wanted me brought to justice. And now I'm here before you, trying to come to terms with my fate. But by watching you and your understanding of death, I can positively see death as comfort. So thank you for that.

Felix: It seems that you have embraced your fate, hmm?

Tristan: It seems that you are in love with yours.

Felix: No, I'm in love with my wife which is why I'm excited about tomorrow!

Tristan: You know what Felix, I'm beginning to feel better about tomorrow as well. Thank you.

Felix: (a beat) So does that mean that you were in pain earlier? Are you still in any pain because I can help!

Tristan: (chuckles) No, I think I'll be fine for now.

Guard: Alright, you two better get some sleep now. Tomorrow's events are scheduled early and you should be fully awake to give your last words. Goodnight and I pray that you both have seen your actions in a new light.

Tristan: Thank you Felix.

Felix: What are you thanking me for this time?

Tristan: For keeping my mind off of the fact that this is my last day on Earth. Tomorrow I will descend into Tartarus but I haven't spent all this time thinking on my fate but rather on you and your story and your… uniqueness.

Felix: That's so kind of you! I suppose I should thank you too!

Tristan: For what?

Felix: For reigniting my enthusiasm for being able to meet my family once more on the morrow! I hope they won't be bother by the fact that I helped them with their pain without asking them… But physicians help unconscious patients all the time right? Same principle.

Tristan: Hehehe… Whatever you say Felix. (a beat) Goodnight Felix, sleep well.

Felix: Aren't you going to sleep too?

Tristan: Noooooooo I'm going to stay up and uhh… look at the stars!

Felix: But we don’t have a window in our cell.

Tristan: Don’t worry about it Felix, I’m just not tired yet.

Felix: Whatever you say! (falls asleep and begins to snore excitedly)

Tristan: (sigh of relief) I’m not falling asleep in the same room as he is.

Guard: I thought that you were comfortable with the idea of death now.

Tristan: Were you eavesdropping?

Guard: I have been standing outside your cell this entire time, I literally could not help but to overhear all of this.

Tristan: Fine. I may be comfortable with death but not with death by Felix.